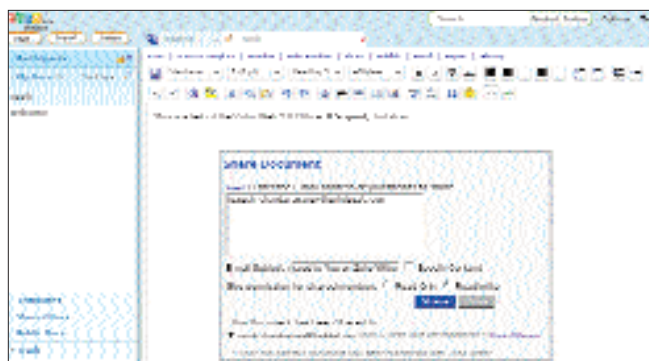




Zoho Writer lets you share your document with others in real time

to register separately for each application, which is mildly irritating, but the registration process is the simplest we've ever seen—just fill in an extra text box—no verification e-mails, no annoying demographic information.

When you get to the applications themselves, it's remarkable how uncannily familiar the environment is—especially Zoho Sheet, which looks and behaves just like Excel. Moreover, unlike in Google Spreadsheets, you can even create charts in this one. The other features are effectively the same, though there's no real-time editing for this one.

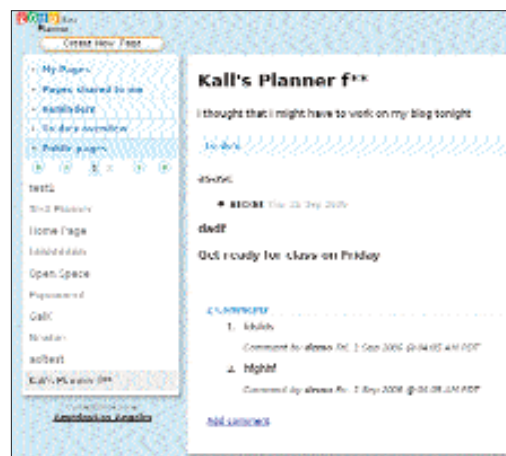
Zoho Writer is an elegant word processor (and you guessed it—it's just like Word), and it, too, tracks changes made to the document, so you can even revert to an older version if you choose. You can share documents or publish them for public view, generate .doc files, PDFs, and even group-edit them in real time.

With Zoho Show, you can create presentations online and import your PowerPoint presentations as well. Given the rest of the suite though, Show is a disappointment—we would have like to see integration with our Zoho

Sheets the way one might have between Excel and PowerPoint, but it's still worthy for creating basic text-and-images presentations.

Zoho Planner is unconventional in the way it behaves, but the interface is quite intuitive, so you shouldn't have problems getting used to it. You can create pages within this organizer that you can make public or share with specific people, and even search and view pages that people have shared publicly.

Zoho also offers you a virtual office called ZohoX, which lets you check your POP e-mail online, share documents, use instant messaging with other members of your virtual office and a calendar to schedule meetings. It's free for individuals, but you'll need to cough up for additional users or if you want the On-Premise version which you can deploy on your office LAN.



You can even view others' Zoho Planners if they let you

Overall, we found that the Zoho suite requires a little more bandwidth than the Google applications, but with a sturdy connection, it's worth it. It's the only one that works with Opera (winning a well-deserved brownie point from most of the *Digit* team), and even has a crucial component that the rest have missed—a spell-checker!

Bottom Line

Should you be uninstalling your office suite and shifting camp online? We'd keep those itchy fingers off. Firstly, while all these applications are quite functional, they're still in beta, so even if you're going to use them, having a local copy is desirable, lest Google hit you with their famous "Oops". You will also require a robust Internet connection—a rare commodity even now. Also, remember that your documents are going to be stored online, so it might not be a good idea to start drawing up your company's balance sheet in Zoho Sheet, or uploading any other confidential and sensitive documents just yet.

Online office suites are a good idea when you and your team are separated by large distances and want to get some basic documentation out of the way, and the future looks promising for the concept in general. ■

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For The Record

ajaxLaunch (www.ajax13.com)

The suite consists of ajaxWrite (the word processor), ajaxSketch for diagrams and flowcharts, ajaxXLS Viewer to view Excel worksheets and an Editor that is still in beta, ajaxPresents for presentations, and ajaxTunes—an online music player.

Targeted more towards the home user, there is little or no collaboration in these applications, and we've frequently encountered server downtimes—your boss might not be too happy if he sees an error message instead of your presentation, we think.

They also aren't really built on AJAX—under the hood is XUL (XML User Interface Language), which only works with Firefox. The team has a long way to go before these programs even come close to Zoho or Google.

iNetOffice (www.inetoffice.com)

Making its debut only about a month ago, iNetOffice has some lofty ambitions—they intend to offer the ability to integrate even with your Web application, so if you want a word processor to offer customers who visit your site, iNetWord (in beta as we write this) will be the application for you. This will take time, however.

We forgive iNetWord for the tacky interface, because all said and done, it offers nearly all the features Zoho does, including the spell-check. You can share folders with other users, but not individual files. The collection of sample documents and images is also quite helpful when you want to preview the application before registering. It does behave weird under Opera, though.

We'll be watching iNetOffice and their (presumably) upcoming applications with considerable interest.